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GRADE: A
PEER REVIEW:

After reading the paper, I found it interesting because it focused on preserving the heritage and identity of Imus City while also considering its future development. I also liked the concept of Baliktanaw since it gave the paper a strong direction and made the proposed strategies feel more connected to the city's history. The discussions on adaptive reuse, heritage spaces, walkability, and conservation areas were also relevant to the issues identified in the study and showed how architecture can play a role in preserving culture and history.

One suggestion I would like to give is regarding the format of the paper. Based on what I learned from Architect Unidad during the checking of my own paper, I think the abstract can already be removed and the discussion can simply flow as one essay. The paper already has a clear flow of ideas, so I feel that presenting it this way would make it more seamless and easier to read. I also think that some parts, especially the discussion on existing challenges and implementation gaps, could be supported with a few more specific examples or data to make the arguments stronger. While the proposed strategies are good, adding a little more detail on how they can be applied in the actual context of Imus would make the recommendations even more convincing.

Overall, I think the paper is well-written and easy to follow. The topic is relevant, especially since many cities today are facing the challenge of balancing development and heritage conservation. The concept of Baliktanaw made the paper stand out, and the proposed strategies were appropriate for the issues being addressed. With a few minor revisions, I believe the paper can be even stronger.



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**Sa Pagitan ng Kasaysayan at Kinabukasan: Revitalizing the Heritage District
of Imus to Strengthen the City's Identity as the Flag Capital of the Philippines**

AR135-1 A58: Architectural Essays and Reviews

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2023100161

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June 19, 2026

Abstract

Imus City, known as the Flag Capital of the Philippines, possesses a rich revolutionary heritage but faces challenges such as the declining visibility of historic landmarks, weak cultural branding, and increasing commercial development. Although the Comprehensive Land Use Plan (CLUP) proposes the Poblacion Culture and Heritage District, many initiatives remain partially implemented, creating a gap between planning intentions and actual urban conditions. This paper explores how heritage-led urban development can revitalize the Heritage District and strengthen Imus City's cultural identity. Anchored on concepts of heritage conservation, cultural identity, and urban revitalization, the study examines the historical significance of Imus, current planning and physical challenges, and the disconnect between policy and implementation. The concept of *Baliktanaw* is introduced as a guiding framework for reconnecting the city with its revolutionary past through design interpretation. The paper proposes strategies such as adaptive reuse of historic structures, integration of cultural narratives in public spaces, development of pedestrian-oriented heritage networks, and establishment of buffer and conservation zones. These interventions aim to enhance cultural tourism, improve heritage visibility, and reinforce place identity. Ultimately, the study argues that heritage-led revitalization can transform Imus into a living cultural landscape that bridges history and contemporary development while strengthening its identity as the Flag Capital of the Philippines.

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I. Introduction

As rapidly urbanizing cities compete for economic growth and investment, heritage districts are increasingly recognized by local governments as important assets that can strengthen local identity, promote tourism, and drive community development. In Imus City, one of the major development thrusts identified in the Comprehensive Land Use Plan is the revitalization of the city's heritage and cultural identity through the proposed Poblacion Culture and Heritage District. The district is envisioned to complement the emergence of growth in commerce and recreation, as it will offer a distinct cultural and historical destination that can attract visitors and reinforce the city's character. However, despite being addressed in the CLUP, the Heritage District concept remains partially implemented. The increasing dominance of commercial development and declining visibility of historical landmarks highlight the need to strengthen Imus City's cultural identity through heritage-led urban development, which will function as a mediator between preservation and progress.

In the case of Imus City, the Poblacion Culture and Heritage District presents a similar opportunity to reconcile modernization with cultural grounding, ensuring that development does not come at the expense of historical identity. Drawing from the concept of *Baliktanaw*, an approach inspired by the Caviteño culture of *baliktad na salita* that symbolizes reconnecting with the past to shape the future, the revitalization of the heritage district through heritage-sensitive design strategies, including adaptive reuse, streetscape improvements, heritage-inspired facades, and cultural interpretation spaces, can strengthen Imus City's identity as the Flag Capital of the Philippines while promoting cultural tourism, heritage conservation, and sustainable urban development.

II. Historical and Cultural Context of Imus

The Province of Cavite is considered one of the cradles of Philippine independence. Like other towns in the historical province, the City of Imus has a colorful past. Established as an independent town in the late eighteenth century after separating from Cavite Viejo (present-day Kawit), Imus evolved from a religious settlement into an important political and economic center during the Spanish colonial period. The town was part of the vast Recollect-owned Hacienda de Imus, which became a focal point of agrarian unrest and resistance against Spanish colonial rule. These social and political conditions contributed to the active participation of Imuseños in the Philippine Revolution of 1896.

The historical significance of Imus is most evident in its role during the struggle for Philippine independence. The city was the site of key revolutionary events, including the Battle of Alapan on May 28, 1898, where Filipino revolutionary forces led by General Emilio Aguinaldo achieved a decisive victory against Spanish troops. Following this triumph, the Philippine flag sewn in Hong Kong was first unfurled for the first time in victory against Spanish forces. This event established Imus as the "Flag Capital of the Philippines" and remains central to its cultural identity today. Over the years, Imus transformed from a rural municipality into a highly urbanized city through rapid industrial, commercial, and residential development. Despite this growth, the city continues to celebrate its revolutionary heritage through cultural traditions such as the Wagayway Festival and the preservation of historical landmarks, reflecting the enduring importance of history and national identity in shaping the character of Imus.

III. Heritage-Led Urban Development

Given Imus City's rich revolutionary history as the site of the first unfolding of the Philippine flag, it presents a unique opportunity to leverage heritage as a driver of urban development. Rather than allowing modernization to overshadow the city's cultural identity, heritage-led urban development integrates cultural heritage conservation into broader urban planning and development strategies, ensuring that growth and preservation can coexist. This approach recognizes historical and cultural assets as valuable resources that can contribute to economic growth, tourism development, community identity, and urban sustainability (Cruz & Roldan, 2024). Heritage districts are therefore treated not only as remnants of the past but also as active components of contemporary city-making.

According to the study of Cruz and Roldan (2024), cultural heritage can function alongside development and serve as an important pillar of sustainable urban growth. Their study on heritage conservation and tourism development emphasizes that heritage preservation contributes to economic vitality by promoting cultural tourism, generating employment opportunities, and supporting creative industries. Furthermore, heritage-driven urban revitalization can create social, economic, and environmental benefits while strengthening a community's sense of identity and belonging. Recent studies on the revitalization of urban historic districts further argue that heritage conservation should extend beyond the preservation of individual buildings. Effective revitalization requires a comprehensive approach that considers urban planning, public activity, and the overall vitality of heritage areas. Historic districts remain relevant when they are integrated into everyday urban life through accessible public spaces, cultural

activities, pedestrian networks, and adaptive reuse projects that respond to contemporary needs (Liu et al., 2022). This perspective highlights the importance of creating environments that not only preserve historical significance but also encourage public engagement and economic activity.

In historic urban regions, heritage-led rehabilitation has also been acknowledged as a feasible alternative for demolition and replacement. Heritage investments can generate economic and cultural benefits while maintaining the integrity of historic assets through strategies such as adaptive reuse, restoration, preservation of traditional street patterns, support for local cultural enterprises, and community participation (Throsby & Petetskaya, 2021). These strategies show how local identity and cultural memory can be preserved while heritage conservation supports sustainable urban growth.

In the context of Imus City, the proposed Poblacion Culture and Heritage District reflects the principles of heritage-led urban development. The district seeks to preserve significant heritage sites while introducing pedestrian-friendly streets, adaptive reuse of historic structures, enhanced public spaces, and cultural tourism activities. These interventions align with established heritage revitalization strategies that emphasize the integration of preservation, public engagement, and economic development. By strengthening the visibility of historical landmarks and celebrating the city's revolutionary history, the Heritage District can reinforce Imus City's identity as the Flag Capital of the Philippines while contributing to sustainable urban growth.

IV. Existing Conditions and Challenges

The Poblacion area functions as the primary heritage center of Imus City, housing key historical landmarks such as the Imus Cathedral, the former City Hall, and Gen. Licerio Topacio Park (now Imus Plaza), which collectively embodies the city's cultural and historical significance. Despite the presence of these heritage resources, the area faces challenges related to cultural visibility, tourism development, and urban character. The increasing dominance of commercial establishments and modern developments has gradually overshadowed the historical significance of these landmarks, limiting their potential to function as major cultural and tourism destinations.

Recognizing the value of its historical legacy, the city government of Imus has identified the revitalization of culture and heritage as a major development thrust in its Comprehensive Land Use Plan (CLUP). The city envisions rediscovering and strengthening its cultural heritage through the establishment of heritage zones, enhancement of historical and cultural sites, promotion of historical research, and encouragement of public participation through cultural campaigns and programs. These initiatives aim to reinforce local identity, cultivate pride of place among residents, and position heritage as a driver of tourism and economic development. However, many of these strategies remain only partially implemented, resulting in a disconnect between the city's heritage vision and its present urban condition.

Another challenge lies in establishing Imus as a competitive tourism destination despite its strategic location. As a gateway between Metro Manila and major destinations in Cavite such as Tagaytay, thousands of travelers pass through the city daily for employment, recreation, and leisure purposes. Recognizing this opportunity, the city has

adopted a dual strategy that combines cultural heritage and modern recreation within its development framework. Nevertheless, the limited integration of heritage sites, inadequate public spaces, weak heritage branding, and the lack of a cohesive cultural environment continue to hinder the city's ability to attract and retain visitors. As a result, many heritage resources remain underutilized and disconnected from the city's broader tourism and development agenda.

A significant challenge in the realization of the heritage district is the gap between planning and implementation. Although the CLUP outlines strategies for heritage conservation and cultural revitalization, many of the proposed projects have yet to be fully realized. This implementation gap may be attributed to several factors, including shifting development priorities, limited funding, administrative constraints, and changes in local leadership over time. As successive administrations may prioritize different programs and projects, long-term heritage initiatives can experience delays or reduced attention. Consequently, the envisioned heritage district has yet to achieve its full potential as a cultural, tourism, and identity-building asset for the city.

These conditions highlight the need for heritage-sensitive architectural and urban design interventions that can bridge the gap between planning and implementation. By strengthening the physical character, connectivity, and visibility of heritage resources, the proposed revitalization of the Poblacion Culture and Heritage District can transform the area into a vibrant cultural destination while reinforcing Imus City's identity as the Flag Capital of the Philippines.

V. Proposed Architectural Strategies for Revitalization

The proposed revitalization of the Poblacion Culture and Heritage District is guided by the concept of *Baliktanaw*, inspired by the Caviteño culture of using *baliktad na salita* or reversed words. As a cultural expression unique to the province, this practice serves as a metaphor for looking back to move forward. In the context of heritage revitalization, *Baliktanaw* represents the act of revisiting Imus City's revolutionary past in order to strengthen its present identity and guide its future development. Rather than viewing heritage as a static reminder of history, the concept encourages the reinterpretation and reintegration of cultural memory into contemporary urban life.

Adaptive Reuse of the Former City Hall as a Cultural Center.

One of the most significant opportunities within the proposed heritage district is the adaptive reuse of the former city hall located in the Poblacion area. According to the Comprehensive Land Use Plan (CLUP) of Imus City, the development of a new city hall is envisioned to symbolize the city's resurgence and continuing transformation into a "Premiere City." As government functions are gradually transferred to the new civic center, the former city hall presents an opportunity to be redeveloped into a cultural facility that preserves its historical significance while serving contemporary community needs. Rather than allowing the structure to become underutilized, the former city hall can be reestablished as a focal point of the city's heritage and culture. Through adaptive reuse, the building can be transformed into a cultural center for Imus that highlights the city's revolutionary history, cultural identity, and contributions to Philippine independence.

Proposed functions include a Flag Capital Museum, interactive exhibits on the Battle of Alapan and the first unfolding of the Philippine flag, cultural archives, community galleries, educational spaces, and venues for cultural programs and events. These facilities would not only preserve cultural memory but also provide opportunities for heritage education and public engagement. The proposed cultural center can serve as the primary embodiment of the *Baliktanaw* concept, allowing visitors to journey back through the city's revolutionary history while fostering a deeper appreciation of its continuing relevance to the growing city of Imus. The redevelopment of the former city hall would also strengthen the role of the Poblacion area as the cultural heart of Imus City. As one of the district's most recognizable civic landmarks, the building can serve as an anchor destination that connects nearby heritage sites such as the Imus Cathedral and Imus Plaza.

Heritage Identity and Cultural Interpretation Through Architecture.

Architecture plays a key role in shaping cultural identity and collective memory. Beyond function, the built environment carries historical narratives, values, and shared community experiences. Heritage, therefore, is not only about preserving old structures but also about communicating the meaning of a place through its spaces, symbols, and everyday urban experience. As the flag capital of the Philippines, Imus possesses a unique historical narrative that can be translated into the design of its heritage district. Instead of relying solely on monuments, historical narratives can be expressed through murals, interpretive walls, public art, signage, and interactive installations. These elements allow history to be experienced in everyday movement through the district.

Architectural and landscape elements may also incorporate symbolic references to the Philippine flag and revolutionary heritage. Paving patterns inspired by the sun and stars of the Philippine flag, commemorative plazas, heritage-themed street furniture, and public gathering spaces can reinforce the city's identity while creating memorable and meaningful places. By integrating these cultural and historical layers into the urban fabric, the heritage district becomes more than a preserved area. The district becomes a living environment that strengthens place identity, supports civic pride, and keeps Imus' heritage visible and relevant for future generations.

Weaving Heritage Through Pedestrian-Oriented and Connected Network Design.

A pedestrian-oriented and connected heritage network strengthens the overall experience of Imus Poblacion. This approach improves both the quality of individual streets and the linkages between key heritage sites, creating a walkable cultural environment. Streetscape enhancements such as widened sidewalks, shaded walkways, heritage-inspired paving, lighting, landscaping, and street furniture help make movement through the district more comfortable, safe, and engaging. At a larger scale, these improved streets form part of a continuous heritage trail that connects important sites such as the Imus Cathedral, former City Hall, Imus Plaza, Alapan, and other historical landmarks. Through pedestrian pathways, bicycle lanes, wayfinding systems, and interpretive signage, the district becomes an integrated cultural route rather than isolated destinations. This combined strategy promotes sustainable mobility while allowing visitors and residents to experience Imus' heritage as a cohesive and meaningful journey.

Heritage Buffer and Conservation Zones.

Establishing buffer and conservation zones that prevent incompatible development from lessening the cultural significance of historic resources is necessary for ensuring their preservation. According to the National Historical Commission of the Philippines (NHCP) Guidelines for Historic Centers, heritage zones must be supported by regulatory controls that manage land use, building form, and development intensity to ensure the preservation of historic character and spatial integrity. These measures may include building height controls, signage regulations, setback requirements, and design review guidelines for developments located near or within heritage contexts. The NHCP guidelines emphasize that protecting not only individual structures but also their surrounding environment is essential in maintaining the authenticity and cultural value of historic areas. This approach reinforces the role of buffer zones in sustaining visual coherence and preventing disruptive development within heritage settings.

VI. Conclusion

When viewed through the concept of *Baliktanaw*, these architectural and urban design strategies provide a comprehensive framework for revitalizing the Heritage District and strengthening Imus City's identity as the Flag Capital of the Philippines. The concept symbolizes the act of looking back to rediscover the historical narratives that shaped the city. Through the adaptive reuse of historic structures, the integration of cultural narratives into architecture and public spaces, the creation of walkable and connected heritage networks, and the establishment of buffer and conservation zones, the district can better preserve, communicate, and celebrate its revolutionary heritage.

By transforming legacy from a passive historical asset into an active part of daily urban life, these interventions enable locals and tourists to interact more deeply with the city's past. More than preserving landmarks, these strategies create a distinct and recognizable cultural environment that differentiates Imus from other rapidly urbanizing cities. As a result, the district can serve not only as a center for heritage conservation and cultural tourism but also as a lasting symbol of Imus City's historical significance and its enduring role in the nation's journey toward independence. *Baliktanaw* demonstrates how revisiting history can become a catalyst for cultural revitalization, ensuring that the legacy of the first unfolding of the Philippine flag remains visible and deeply embedded within the city's future development.

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